

QED SHANKKAR AIYAR

Out Of Body Thoughts



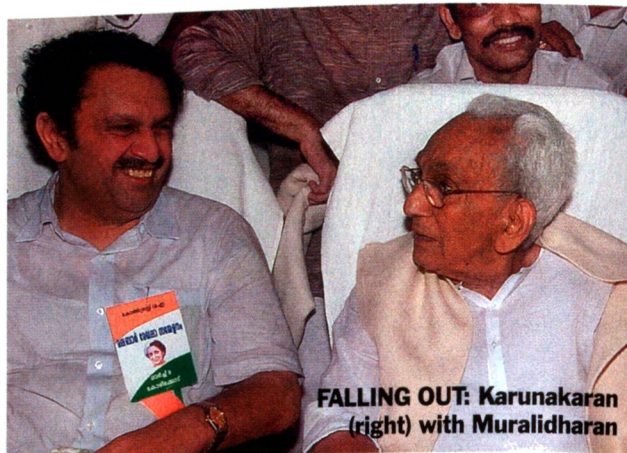
Last week, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh spoke yet again—rather, he had an out of body experience again. There are clearly two of them—one who is the prime minister and another who steps out of the body to intellectualise the distance between articulation and action, very simply what didn't happen. There is a pattern that precedes the event—the trapped intellectual gasps for free thought and most often finds release at the launch of a book. Last week, the trapped spirit broke out again at the launch of a book by Commerce Minister Kamal Nath to rail against the system. The prime minister worried that “our system doesn't value time” and said that “the decisions that we make or don't make—and that applies to politicians, businessmen, trade unions and all other important agents of social change—will have profound implications on the future of our country.”

His frustration is understandable. Almost everything in the policy domain is pending. Since its inception, the UPA regime has specialised in being in “pause mode” thanks to the peculiar dynamics of the coalition where even single-digit parties (with less than 10 MPs) can veto the Government. How often do you hear the finance minister of the country saying it in so many words? But it would be wrong to blame only the Red Brigade or try and pass this off as an area of collective failure by roping in society to share the burden (if it was an attempt to woo empathy, it fails miserably). The honest-to-God truth today is that if something works in the system, it is either private effort or enterprise. If there are bottlenecks, price pressures, inflation or rotten service, it is by definition the government. For four years now, we have heard passionate speeches on reforming the system but have seen little action on the ground. It's lonely at the top, it is tough. One can even appreciate the context, the collective wisdom of ignorance that seems to determine vote-bank politics *but* the buck stops at the prime minister's desk.

In July the prime minister—again at a book release—said it's “not always easy to judge whether any given outcome is a product of the capabilities of the leader or the inadequacies of the environment in which he or she must function.” The inadequacies of the environment can only be an alibi for failure. Leadership by definition means delivering results. It sounds harsh and is hence the truth.



SAURASH SINGH



FALLING OUT: Karunakaran (right) with Muralidharan

Back to the Beginning

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Former chief minister K. Karunakaran and his son K. Muralidharan have fallen out over the former's attempt to leave NCP and return to the Congress. “He returns only to get humiliated by Sonia Gandhi and the leadership. A 90-year-old's last wish to return to his original party should be respected. But why did he leave that party when he was 87?” asks NCP state president Muralidharan, who suspended six general secretaries for going with his father. Karuna-

karan, who has spent the past 20 years helping his son carve a political career at the cost of his own political ruin, says, “I want to return to where I belong.” His proposed return has won support even from somebody who was once his arch enemy—Union Defence Minister A.K. Antony. However, former chief minister Oommen Chandy and KPCC President Ramesh Chennithala want to keep the wily leader out. He now awaits a clearance from another past foe, Sonia.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

Portrait of a Conflict

AMRITSAR The Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC), the apex religious body of the Sikhs, controlled by Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal, has become embroiled in an unsavoury row over the installation of a portrait of slain militant leader Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale at the Golden Temple. SGPC had been under pressure from splinter factions who had threatened a “commando action” to install Bhindranwale's portrait in the

temple if the committee could not, by November 30. The life-size portrait presents Bhindranwale as the “greatest Sikh warrior of the 20th century”. SGPC's step—which could not have been possible without Badal's consent—has led to strong reactions from the opposition Congress which has accused the Akalis of pandering to fundamentalist fringe. Badal maintains that the portrait poses no threat to peace in the state.

by Ramesh Vinayak